The Bamboo Principle

A practical way of thinking about change when progress is hard to see.

Bamboo is a useful metaphor for change because it challenges the expectation that progress should be visible straight away. Someone chooses to plant it and takes the first step. After that, however, there can be a long period where very little seems to happen. It is watered, the conditions are maintained, and from the outside it can look much the same as it did before.

That can be a difficult stage in any change process. We tend to look for evidence that what we are doing is working and, when we cannot see it, it is easy to conclude that it isn't. This is often the point where people become discouraged and stop doing the very things that might eventually make a difference. The important part of the bamboo metaphor is that this apparently quiet period is not necessarily an inactive one. Below the surface, roots and structure are developing. When bamboo eventually breaks through the ground, its growth is supported by what has already been established.

There is an obvious parallel with some of the people we work with. Early change can be unrewarding. Someone might still be using substances, still struggling with sleep, still anxious, or still dealing with the same circumstances they were dealing with several weeks ago. If our only measure is whether the big problem has disappeared, it can look as though very little has changed.

Look a little closer and there may be more going on. Someone has started attending regularly. They are drinking more water. They have eaten something in the morning three days this week. They have reduced their substance use slightly rather than stopped. They have made one appointment they would previously have missed. Perhaps they came back after a difficult week instead of disappearing. None of those things needs to be exaggerated into a success story. However, they are worth noticing, particularly when we consider what they might be making possible.

Sometimes maintaining what someone has already achieved is significant, especially when their circumstances are difficult. Holding in place can take considerable effort. We should also be careful about assuming that activity necessarily means progress. The question is what difference, if any, these actions are making in the person's life.

We can also easily make motivation the starting point: when I feel better, more confident or more motivated, I'll do something. It can also work the other way round. Someone does something small while motivation is still poor, and what happens next gives them something new to work with. Behaviour can begin to move before confidence catches up. If someone is doing the work but becoming discouraged because they cannot yet see the result, the bamboo principle offers another way of looking at that period. Perhaps there is more happening than they can currently see.

The metaphor does need to be used carefully. It is most useful when there is some identifiable action or process worth maintaining. Without that, it risks becoming reassurance without evidence. It may help us recognise useful work that has yet to produce visible results, but an absence of progress can also be useful information, telling us that we may need to reconsider our approach. The conditions matter, and continuing with something simply because we have already invested time in it is not necessarily helpful.

What have they started that is worth maintaining? What has helped them do it? What is that small action making possible? A short walk might interrupt a familiar pattern of drinking. Eating in the morning might make the rest of the day slightly more manageable. Attending regularly might allow work to happen that could not happen while contact was sporadic. And, where it fits, we can ask what those changes are in the service of. Better health might matter because someone wants to get back to work. Reducing their substance use might matter because they want to be more present with their children. The small action becomes more meaningful when it belongs to something larger.

The metaphor will fit some people and not others. If it fits, use it lightly, then come back to the person's life and what they are actually doing.

The question isn't, "Can we see the bamboo yet?" Sometimes the more useful question is, "What are we doing now that is worth continuing?"